Family Backup Service: Templates

Four templates: break glass sheet, backup agreement, "if I'm hit by a bus" letter, and exit document. Replace everything in [brackets]. These are starting points, not legal advice. Have a lawyer review the agreement if the stakes or the group grow.

1. Break Glass Sheet

How to create and maintain it

- **One sheet per household**, printed (not just a file). The point is that it works when the phone, laptop and accounts are all unavailable.
- **Never write the master password on it.** Write where it can be found or who holds it. Passwords and recovery codes go in the password manager; the sheet points to them.
- **Store two copies:** one in a fireproof box or safe at home, one off-site with a trusted person (sealed envelope) or in a safe deposit box.
- **Review every 6 months** and after any phone change, new account, new password manager, or change of trusted contact. Set a recurring calendar reminder. Initial and date each review at the bottom.
- **Keep it short.** One page. If it needs two, people will not keep it current.
- **Recovery codes:** print the codes for the email account, the password manager, and the Apple or Google account, and attach them behind the sheet. Cross each code off when used and regenerate the set.

Example sheet

EMERGENCY ACCESS SHEET: The [Family Name] Household

Last reviewed: [date] | Next review due: [date]

If you are reading this, something has gone wrong (lost or stolen phone, locked account, illness, or death). Stay calm. Everything needed to get back in is below or in the password manager.

1. Password manager

- Service: Bitwarden ([bitwarden.com] or [vault.yourdomain.com])
- Account email: [email address]

- Master password: NOT written here. It is [held by: name / sealed in envelope in the safe / known to the account owner]
- Emergency contacts with vault access: [Name 1], [Name 2]
- Printed recovery code and 2FA recovery code: attached behind this page

2. Key accounts (details live in the password manager)

Account	Login email	Recovery contact / method
Primary email	[email]	[backup email / phone / printed codes]
Apple ID / Google Account	[email]	[Recovery Contact: name]
Phone carrier	[carrier, account holder]	PIN is in the password manager
Bank / primary financial	[institution]	[branch phone number]
Cloud backup (Mega / Proton / other)	[email]	codes in the password manager

3. Phone lost or stolen: do this in order

1. From any device, sign in to [Find My / Find Hub] and mark the phone as lost.
2. Call the carrier ([number]) and suspend the SIM so nobody can receive your verification codes.
3. Sign in to the password manager from another device and change the email and Apple/Google passwords.
4. File a police report if stolen.
5. Call [backup admin name, number] to restore photos and documents from the backup.

4. Where the backups are

- Photos and documents are copied automatically by [Your Name] to a private server and to encrypted off-site storage.
- A second copy sits on a drive at [location, e.g. "the hall closet"] and is encrypted.
- To get anything back, call [Your Name]: [phone]. Backup admin if unreachable: [Name, phone].

5. Important people

- Lawyer: [name, phone]
- Financial advisor: [name, phone]
- Doctor: [name, phone]
- Executor / trusted person: [name, phone]

6. Where physical documents are

[Will, deeds, passports, insurance policies: location of safe, key location]

Review log: [date / initials] [date / initials] [date / initials]

2. Backup Service Agreement

A short, plain-language agreement between friends and family. Its purpose is to make expectations clear, not to be adversarial.

FAMILY BACKUP SERVICE AGREEMENT

This agreement is between **[Your Full Name]** ("the Host") and **[Participant Full Name(s)]** ("the Participant"), effective **[date]**.

1. What this is

The Host will keep an automatic, secondary copy of the Participant's photos, videos and selected documents ("the Data") to protect against loss from device failure, theft, accidental deletion or account lockout. This is a favor between people who trust each other. It is not a commercial service, and the Host is not a professional data custodian.

2. What is backed up

- Devices and accounts included: [list, e.g. "Jane's Android phone photos, Documents folder"]
- Not included: [e.g. app data, messages, email, anything not listed above]
- The Participant is responsible for keeping the backup app installed and running. The Host will monitor for stalled backups and will tell the Participant if one is detected, but cannot guarantee that every file is captured.

3. How the Data is stored and protected

- The Data is kept on equipment the Host controls, with at least one encrypted off-site copy and, where agreed, a copy on a drive at the Participant's home.
- The Host will use reasonable security measures: encryption, strong authentication, and software updates.

- Backups are tested periodically by restoring sample files.

4. Privacy

- The Host will not view, copy, share or use the Data except as needed to maintain the service, restore files at the Participant's request, or comply with the law.
- As administrator, the Host technically has the ability to access the Data. Participants who want some documents hidden even from the Host may encrypt those files themselves (for example with Cryptomator) before they are backed up.
- The Host will not share the Data with anyone other than the Participant without their permission, except as required by law.
- Other households' data is stored separately and is not accessible to the Participant.

5. Restoring

The Participant can ask the Host to restore any or all of the Data. The Host will make a reasonable effort to do so within [e.g. 3 days]. The Host will not hand over the Data to anyone else claiming to be the Participant without verifying identity, for example a call-back to a known number.

6. Costs

- [Option A: The Host covers the ongoing costs as a gift.]
- [Option B: The Participant contributes $[amount] per [month/year] toward storage costs, payable [method].]
- [Hardware: any drive or device placed at the Participant's home is [owned by the Participant / on loan from the Host].]

7. No guarantee

The Host will take care but cannot guarantee that the Data will never be lost or damaged. The service is a safety net, not a replacement for the Participant's own habits. The Participant agrees the Host is not liable for loss of data, except in cases of deliberate misconduct. Nothing here limits the Participant's right to keep their own copies elsewhere, and the Participant is encouraged to do so.

8. Prohibited content

The Participant will not store illegal material in the backup. The Host may remove such material and end the arrangement.

9. Ending the arrangement

Either party may end this agreement at any time with [30] days' notice, or immediately if circumstances require. On ending, the Exit Procedure (separate document) applies: the Participant receives a complete copy of the Data and the Host deletes their copies.

10. If the Host becomes unavailable

The Host has named a backup administrator, **[Name, contact]**, who can provide the Participant a copy of the Data if the Host cannot. The Participant consents to this person accessing the Data solely for that purpose.

11. Changes

Changes must be agreed by both parties in writing (text or email is fine).

Signed:

Host: _____ Date: _____

Participant: _____ Date: _____

3. "If I'm Hit by a Bus" Letter

How to use it

- Address it to your backup administrator, plus a copy for your spouse or executor if appropriate.
- **Do not include passwords or keys in the letter.** Put them in a sealed envelope in a safe, or give access through the password manager's emergency-access feature, and say where it is.
- Review and re-date it every 6 to 12 months or when you change providers or add a household.

Example letter

To: [Backup Administrator Name] **From:** [Your Name] **Date:** [date] **Re:** What to do if I can't run the family backup service

Dear [Name],

If you are reading this, I'm unable to keep the family backup running, whether through illness, an accident or death. I'm sorry to hand you this, and thank you for being willing to help. Take your time. Nothing here is urgent in the first week unless someone has lost their phone.

What this is

I keep automatic backups of photos and documents for these households: [list households and contact numbers]. Each has a written agreement with me. The backups exist so nobody loses irreplaceable photos or documents. They are not accessible to anyone else, and I would like them kept private.

Where everything is

- **Primary server:** a Proxmox machine at [location]. It runs a separate virtual environment for each household.
- **Off-site copy 1:** Backblaze B2, bucket [name], account email [email].
- **Off-site copy 2:** Hetzner Storage Box, account email [email].
- **Household drives:** each household also has its own encrypted drive. If everything else fails, these hold their data.
- **Documentation:** [Git repo / folder / notebook location] has the setup, restore steps and a diagram.

How to get access

- My password manager has emergency access set up for you. Request access through [Bitwarden Emergency Access]; after the waiting period you will see the "Server and Backups" folder.
- A sealed envelope marked "Backup Service" is in [location]. It holds the Proxmox root credentials, the backup repository passphrases, and the two-factor recovery codes.
- **Without the repository passphrases, the off-site backups cannot be opened. Please do not throw away the envelope.**

What to do, in order

1. **Tell the households.** Message each household using the contact list below. Reassure them their data is safe. Ask them not to delete anything from their phones for now.
2. **Keep the lights on.** The monthly provider bills are paid by [card / account]. If that card is closed, update billing at Backblaze and Hetzner first. A lapsed bill could delete backups.
3. **Choose a path.**
    - *Simplest:* give each household their drive and a copy of their data, then wind down (see below).
    - *Continue:* if you or someone else wants to keep running it, the documentation covers upgrades and monitoring. It is fine to say no.

4. **Restoring for someone:** follow the "Restore" page in the documentation. Verify the person's identity first by calling a number you already know.
5. **Winding down:** hand each household a full copy of their data (the Exit Procedure document describes how), confirm they can open it, then delete their data from the server and both off-site stores, and cancel the accounts.

What not to do

- Don't open or browse anyone's photos. Restoring files does not require looking at them.
- Don't let the subscriptions lapse until every household has confirmed receipt of their data.
- Don't expose any service to the internet to make things easier.

People who can help

- Technical help: [name, phone]
- Legal help: [name, phone]
- [Household 1 contact] / [Household 2 contact] / ...

Thank you. Whatever you decide, I trust your judgment.

[Your Name]

4. Exit Procedure

Use when a participant leaves the service, when the arrangement ends, or when the service winds down. Give a copy to the participant when they join.

BACKUP SERVICE: EXIT PROCEDURE

Applies to: [Participant Name(s)] **Host:** [Your Name]

1. Starting the exit

Either party can start the exit by telling the other (a text is enough). No reason is required. The Host will confirm in writing the date it was received, referred to below as the "Exit Date."

2. Timeline

When	What happens
Exit Date	Backups continue until step 3 is completed. Nothing is deleted.
Within 7 days	The Host prepares a complete copy of the Participant's Data and decides with the Participant how to deliver it.
Within 14 days	The Participant receives the copy and confirms it opens.
Within 30 days of confirmation	The Host deletes the Data from all systems and tells the Participant when finished.

3. Delivering the Data

- The Host will provide the Data in standard formats: original photo and video files, documents in their original folders, and an export of albums or metadata where possible.
- Delivery is by [encrypted external drive / the household's existing replica drive / a download link]. If a drive is used, the Host will tell the Participant the encryption passphrase separately.
- The Participant agrees to open and spot-check the files before the Host deletes anything. The Host will not delete the Data until the Participant confirms or [60] days pass after a written reminder, whichever comes first.

4. Deleting the Data

The Host will delete the Participant's Data from:

- the primary server, including snapshots;
- off-site storage (Backblaze B2 and Hetzner), including previous versions;
- any Host-held copy on external drives or the Host's own devices.

Because off-site copies may keep versions for a retention period, some data may remain in encrypted form for up to [90] days before expiring. During that time it cannot be read without the Host's keys, and the Host will not restore it. If the Participant wants complete deletion faster, the Host will [destroy the encryption key for the Participant's repository / ask the provider to purge versions].

The Host will confirm completion by message, listing what was deleted.

5. Hardware

Any drive or device at the Participant's home belongs to [the Participant / the Host]. If owned by the Host, the Host will collect it. In either case, the Host will remove its remote access (VPN keys, accounts) from the device.

6. Costs

No fee is charged for the exit. If the Participant has contributed to costs, [no refund is owed / a pro-rated amount is returned].

7. If the relationship has become difficult

The Participant's right to a full copy of their Data does not depend on the reason for the exit. The Host will not hold the Data back or withhold it because of any disagreement. Handover can be done through a mutually trusted third party if preferred.

8. Confirmation

Participant confirms: I have received and checked my Data. Signed: _____ Date: _____

Host confirms: I have deleted the Data as described. Signed: _____ Date: _____